

3 A.M. Thoughts

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A Teen Journal for Nighttime Worry & Sleep

NORTH STAR JOURNALS

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This journal is intended for self-reflection and general well-being. It is not a substitute for professional mental-health care. If you are struggling, please reach out to a trusted adult, counselor, or crisis line. In the U.S., call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline). Outside the U.S., see findahelpline.com.

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For every worry that only shows up in the dark.

HOW TO USE THIS JOURNAL

This is your journal. Use it in whatever order helps. Skip pages. Come back to pages. Nothing here is a test.

There are five sections. Grounding tools you can use in the moment. Prompts to help you get thoughts out of your head and onto paper. Trackers to spot patterns. A toolkit of small practices. And eight weeks of short reflections.

Try one prompt when your mind is loud. Try one tracker for a week. If a page feels wrong for you today, turn to another one. Progress is not linear, and neither is this book.

There are no wrong answers here. Write in pencil, pen, whatever. Scribble. Draw. Leave pages blank. This journal will not grade you.

If your anxiety is getting in the way of your daily life, please also talk to a trusted adult or a mental-health professional. Resources are on the last page.

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SECTION ONE

Start Here

Five grounding tools you can use anywhere.

5-4-3-2-1

Look around. Name five things you can see. Four things you can touch. Three things you can hear. Two things you can smell. One thing you can taste. Go slow. Your senses pull you back into your body.

NOTES

BOX BREATHING

Breathe in for four counts. Hold for four. Breathe out for four. Hold for four. Repeat four times. Draw a square in the air with your finger as you breathe, one side per count.

NOTES

BODY SCAN

Start at the top of your head. Slowly move your attention down: forehead, jaw, shoulders, chest, belly, arms, hands, legs, feet. Notice what's tight. Let it soften if it wants to. If it doesn't, that's fine.

NOTES

COLD WATER RESET

Splash cold water on your face, or hold an ice cube for a few seconds, or run your wrists under cold water for thirty seconds. The temperature shift interrupts the anxiety loop and signals your nervous system to slow down.

NOTES

NAME IT TO TAME IT

Say out loud, or write down, exactly what you're feeling. "I feel anxious because..." Being specific about the emotion — not just 'bad' — shrinks it a little. Try to name three feelings if you can.

NOTES

SECTION TWO

Prompts

For the hours you are supposed to be sleeping.

What thought is keeping you up tonight? Write it out until it thins.

What did today ask of you? Write it down, so you can put it here instead of in bed.

What are you carrying into tonight that isn't yours to carry?

What time did the worry start? What were you doing? What were you not doing?

Write a list of everything on your mind. All of it. Then close the book.

What does your body need right now that it isn't getting? Water, food, warmth, quiet?

What are you telling yourself about not being able to sleep? Is that true?

What is one thing you could do tomorrow instead of solving it tonight?

What is your bed like right now — safe, tense, comforting? Describe it.

What did today go right, even a little? Name three things.

What conversation from today is looping? Write the ending you wish it had.

What are you afraid of forgetting? Write it here so your brain can let it go.

What are you grateful for tonight? Something small counts.

What has your worry never actually solved at 3 a.m.? What has it cost you?

What did you do today that was hard? Take a second to notice that.

What is the story your brain is telling in the dark? Would you believe it in daylight?

What would you tell yourself in six hours if you saw yourself wide awake now?

What does 'a good enough night of sleep' look like tonight? Not perfect.

What is one comfort you can bring into bed with you? Sound, scent, warmth, memory?

What tomorrow-you problem is worrying you? Write a note to tomorrow-you about it.

What are you missing tonight? Home, a person, a version of yourself?

What is one thing you can let go of, just until morning?

What is the sound of your room right now? What if you named it out loud?

What is the loudest worry? Give it a name. Set it aside for the night.

What is the last kind thing anyone said to you? Say it back to yourself.

What did today teach you? Even one small thing.

What are you refusing to feel that might be part of why you can't sleep?

What is your morning going to need from you? Write it out, so you can rest.

What is a memory of feeling safe? Bring yourself back to it now, slowly.

Finish this: 'It is okay if tonight is not perfect. I can...'

SECTION THREE

Trackers

Notice the patterns in your sleep and nighttime worry.

ANXIETY LEVEL THIS WEEK

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT TRIGGERED IT	WHAT HELPED
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

SLEEP TRACKER

DAY	HOURS	HOW I SLEPT	HOW I FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

MOOD CHECK-IN

DAY	MORNING	AFTERNOON	NIGHT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

SLEEP AND NIGHTTIME WORRY LOG

DAY	WHERE / WHEN	BODY FEELING	WHAT I DID NEXT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

ENERGY THIS WEEK

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT DRAINED ME	WHAT REFILLED ME
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

ONE SMALL WIN

DAY	WIN OF THE DAY	WHO SAW IT	HOW IT FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

KINDNESS TO SELF

DAY	WHAT I DID	HOW IT FELT	DO AGAIN?
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

ANXIETY LEVEL THIS WEEK

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KINDNESS TO SELF

DAY	WHAT I DID	HOW IT FELT	DO AGAIN?
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

SECTION FOUR

Your Toolkit

Small practices you can return to on hard days.

WORRY PARKING

Write every worry in your head on a page. Close the book. Tell yourself: 'It will still be here in the morning if I need it.' Then close your eyes.

THE WIND-DOWN HOUR

Design your last hour before bed. No screens? Warm shower? Herbal tea? Book? Write the plan here, then try it for a week.

4-7-8 BREATHING

Breathe in for 4 counts. Hold for 7. Breathe out for 8. Repeat four cycles. This slows your nervous system on purpose.

PROGRESSIVE MUSCLE RELEASE

Starting at your feet: squeeze the muscles for 5 seconds, then release. Move up your body — legs, belly, hands, jaw. Notice the drop.

MENTAL UNPACKING

Say out loud (or write): 'Tomorrow I will handle X. Tomorrow I will handle Y.' Give your brain permission to hand things off to future-you.

THE RESET IF YOU CAN'T SLEEP

If you're wide awake after 20 minutes, get up. Go to another room. Do something low-stakes. Come back when your body is heavier.

SAFE-PLACE VISUALIZATION

Bring a real or imagined safe place to mind. Water, trees, your childhood bedroom, whatever. Describe every sense: what you see, hear, smell.

THE GRATITUDE THREE

Before your head hits the pillow, name three good things from today. Small counts. Toast that wasn't burnt counts.

BODY SCAN FOR SLEEP

Starting at the top of your head, notice each part of your body and let it soften. Forehead. Jaw. Shoulders. Chest. Belly. All the way down.

NOTE TO TOMORROW-YOU

Write one sentence tomorrow-you needs to read first thing. Something honest and kind. Leave it on the nightstand.

AFFIRMATIONS

Write down phrases that feel true (or that you want to be true). Circle the ones that help most. Come back to them.

- I do not have to solve this tonight.
- Rest counts, even when I'm not asleep.
- The morning will meet me. I do not have to meet it early.
- It is okay to be awake right now.
- My body is doing its best.
- This thought can wait for daylight.
- I am safe in this bed.
- Tomorrow-me can handle tomorrow.

NOTES

SECTION FIVE

Weekly Reflections

Eight weeks of looking back and forward.

WEEK 1 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 1 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 2 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 2 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 3 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 3 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 4 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 4 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 5 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 5 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 6 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 6 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 7 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 7 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 8 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 8 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WHEN YOU NEED MORE HELP

This journal is for reflection, not treatment. If your anxiety is getting in the way of school, sleep, eating, friendships, or feeling safe, please talk to a trusted adult, a school counselor, or a therapist.

If you are in crisis:

- U.S. — Call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline).
- U.S. — Text HOME to 741741 (Crisis Text Line).
- U.K. — Call 116 123 (Samaritans).
- Global — findahelpline.com lists lines in your country.

If you or someone else is in immediate danger, call your local emergency number.

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